STORIES FROM THE QURAN : 6

Yunus and the Big Fish

يونس والحوت



Long, long ago, there was a great city beside a river, full of busy streets and markets. More than a hundred thousand people lived there.

Allah sent a prophet to them. His name was Yunus (peace be upon him).



“Worship Allah alone,” Yunus told the people, “and do what is good.” He called them again and again, day after day.

But they shut their doors and would not listen.



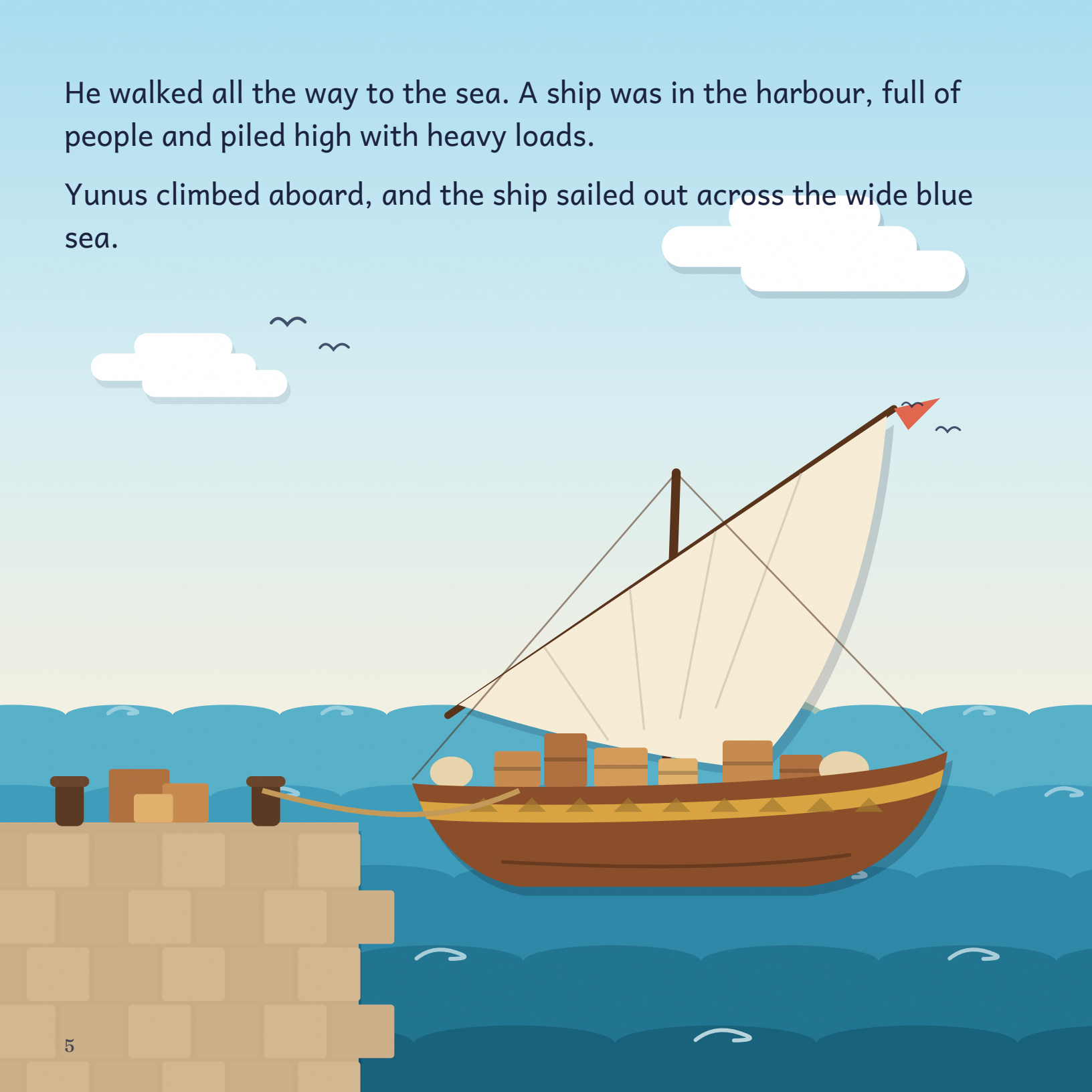
Yunus grew angry and upset with his people, and he left the city.

But he did not wait for Allah to tell him to go. That was his mistake.



He walked all the way to the sea. A ship was in the harbour, full of people and piled high with heavy loads.

Yunus climbed aboard, and the ship sailed out across the wide blue sea.

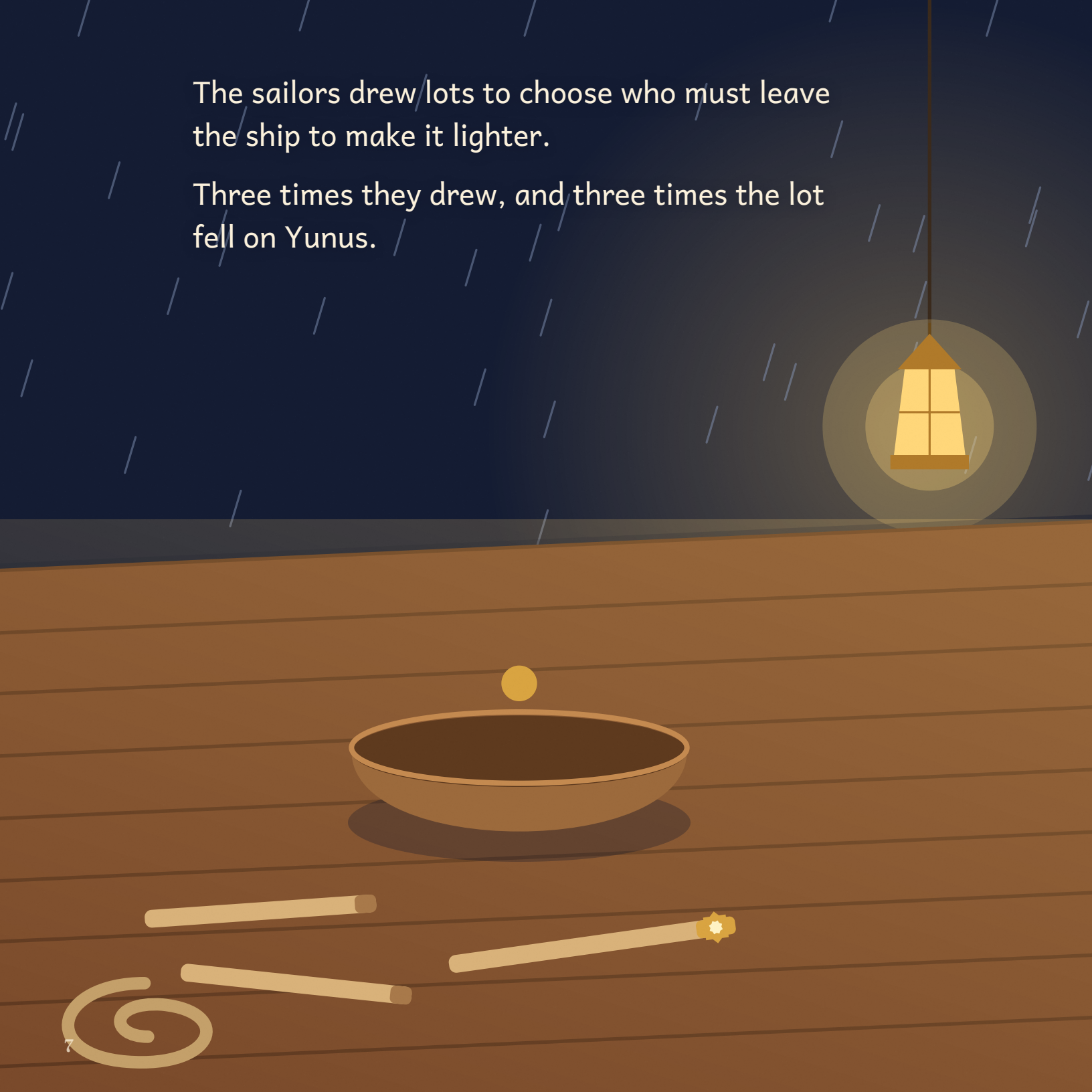


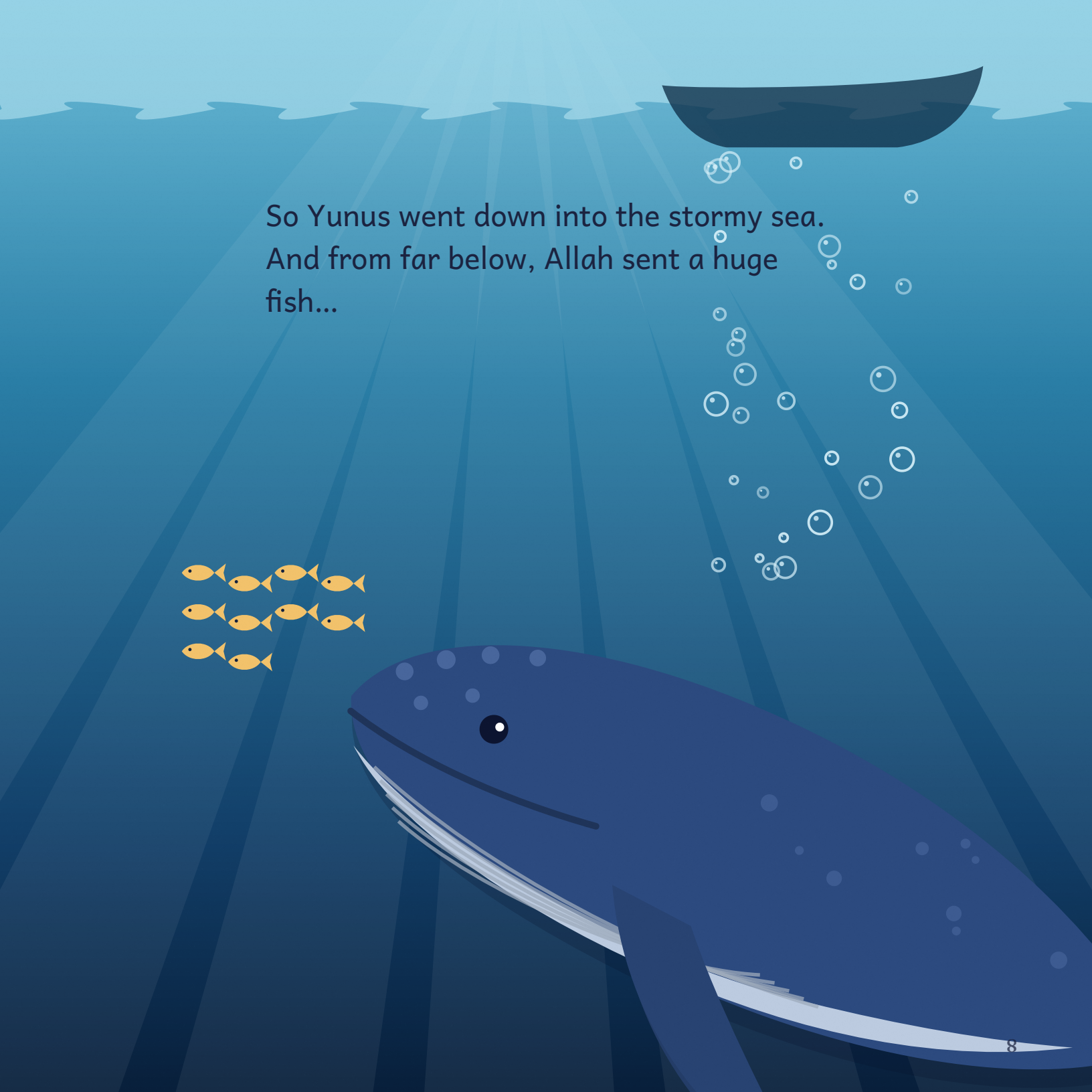
Far from land, the wind began to roar. Great waves crashed over the ship. It was too full, and it was in danger of sinking!



The sailors drew lots to choose who must leave the ship to make it lighter.

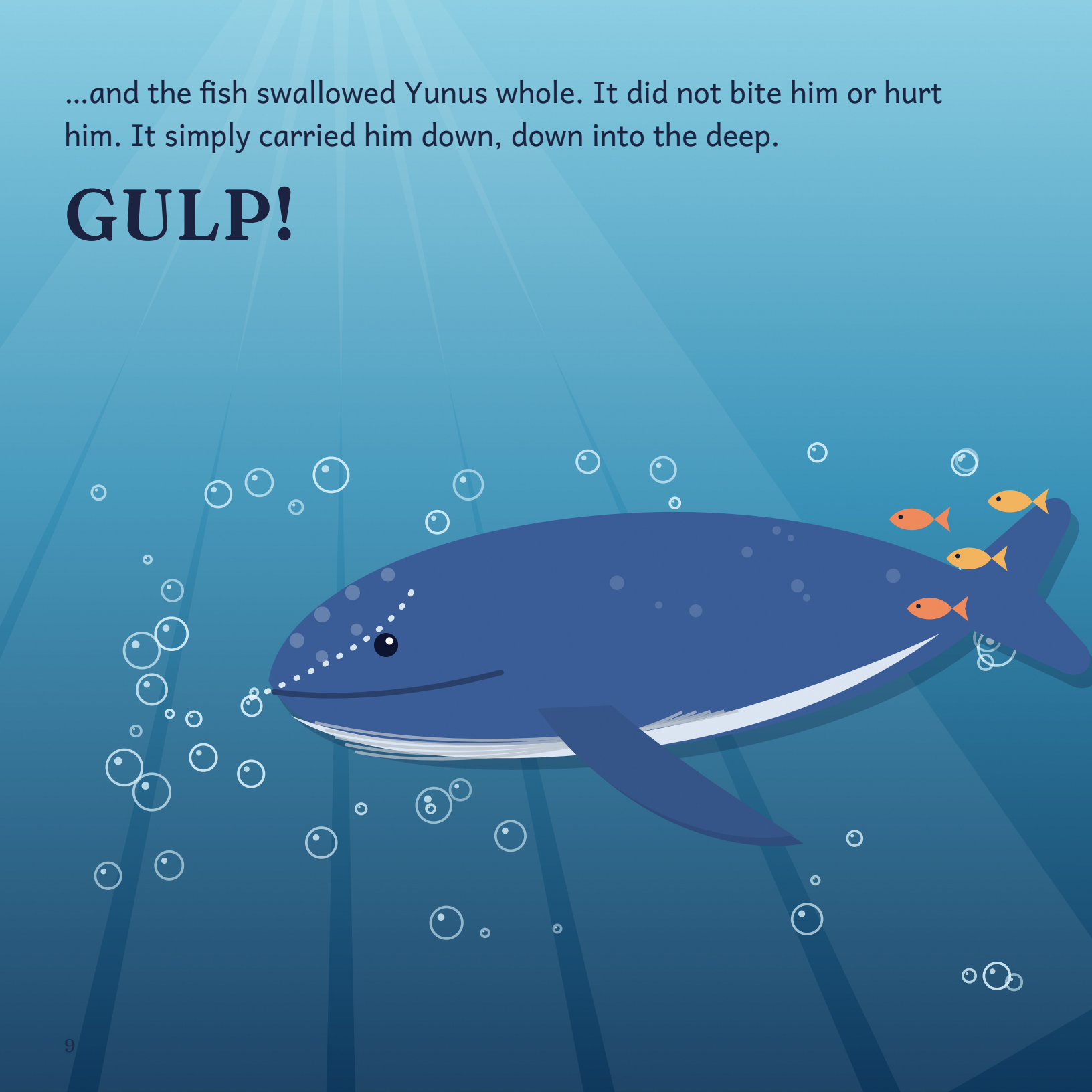
Three times they drew, and three times the lot fell on Yunus.




So Yunus went down into the stormy sea.
And from far below, Allah sent a huge
fish...

...and the fish swallowed Yunus whole. It did not bite him or hurt him. It simply carried him down, down into the deep.

GULP!





Inside the fish it was dark.

Dark inside the fish. Dark in the deep sea. Dark in the night. Three darknesses, one inside another.

In the darkness, Yunus remembered Allah. He knew he had done wrong, and he called out:

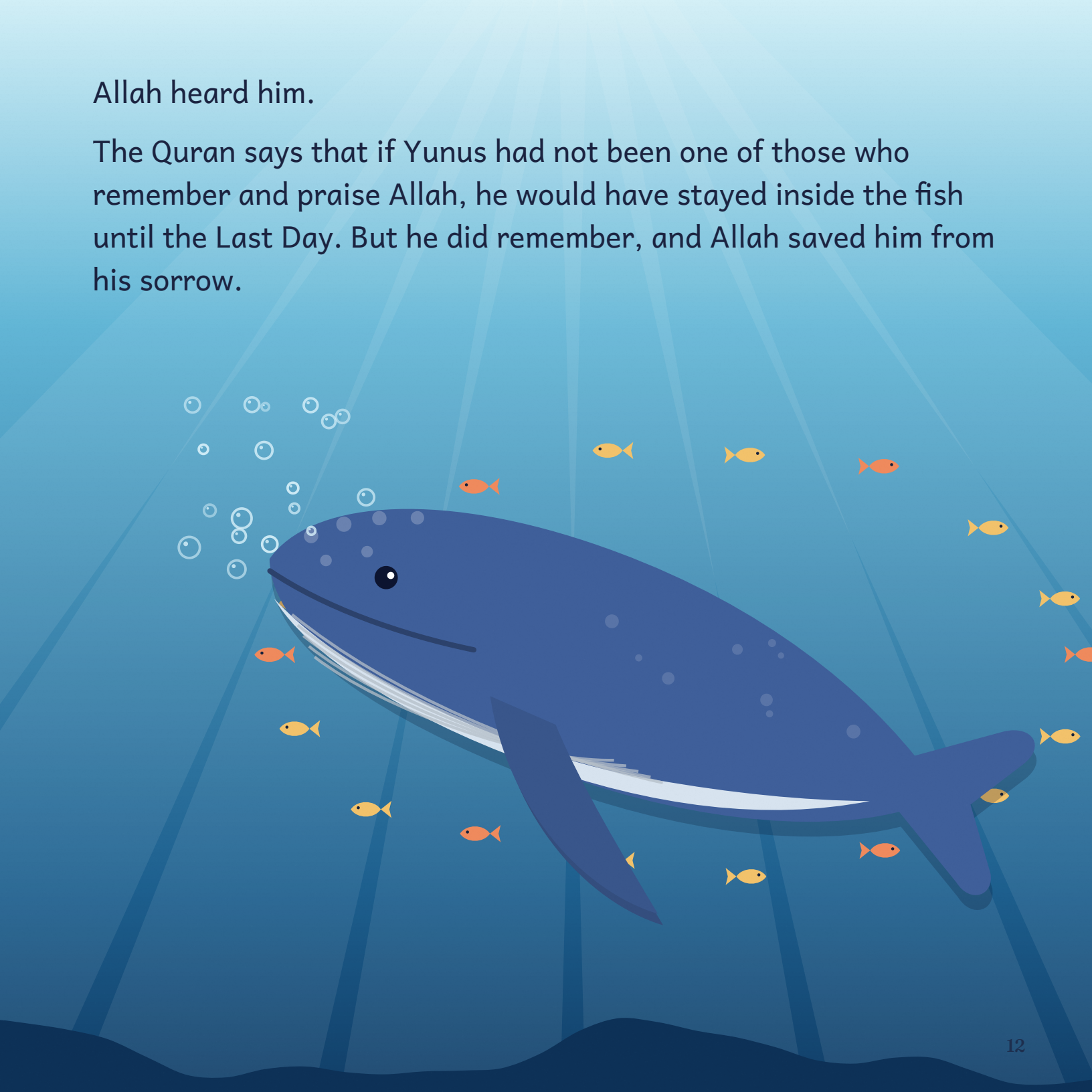
لَّآ إِلَٰهَ إِلَّآ أَنتَ سُبْحَٰنَكَ إِنِّى كُنتُ مِنَ ٱلظَّٰلِمِينَ

Lā ilāha illā anta, subḥānaka,
innī kuntu minaẓ-ẓālimīn.

“There is no god but You. Glory be to You!
I have done wrong.”

Allah heard him.

The Quran says that if Yunus had not been one of those who remember and praise Allah, he would have stayed inside the fish until the Last Day. But he did remember, and Allah saved him from his sorrow.



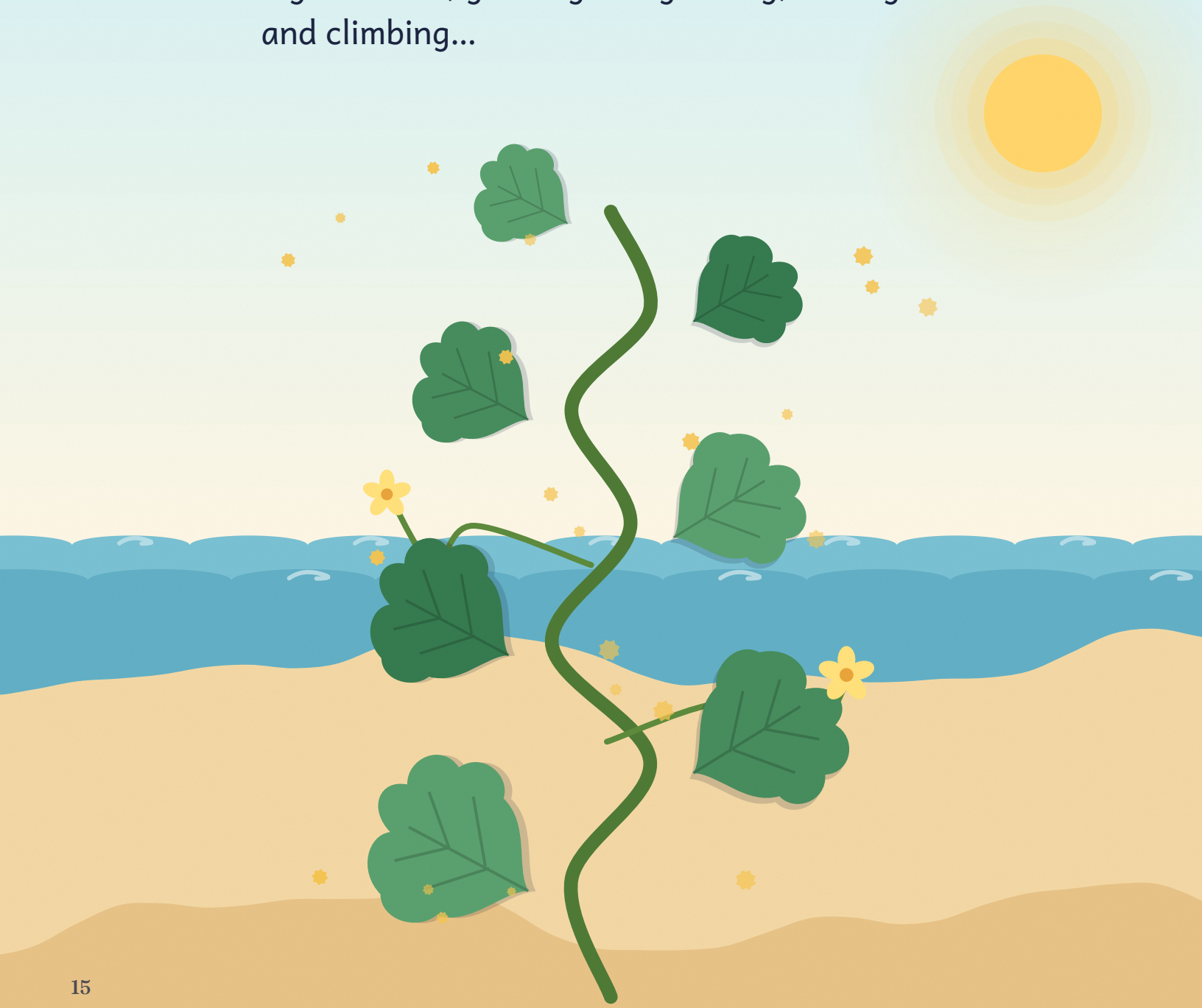
The great fish swam up from the deep, all the way to the shore, and there it put Yunus out onto the sand.





The shore was bare, with no trees and no shade at all. The sun beat down, and Yunus was weak and ill.

Then Allah made a plant grow up over him, a gourd vine, growing and growing, curling and climbing...





...until its big, wide leaves made a cool green shade. There Yunus rested and ate, until he was well and strong again.

Then Allah sent Yunus back to his people. While he had been away, they had seen signs of Allah's punishment coming, and they had turned to Allah.



And this time, they believed, more than a hundred thousand of them! Allah took the punishment away, and they lived in peace for a long time.

They are the only town in the Quran that believed just in time.



Say Yunus's prayer

One piece at a time. You can say it whenever you feel scared or sad, or when you have done something wrong.

لَّآ إِلَٰهَ إِلَّآ أَنتَ

Lā ilāha illā anta

There is no god but You.

سُبْحَٰنَكَ

subḥānaka

Glory be to You!

إِنِّى كُنتُ مِنَ ٱلظَّٰلِمِينَ

innī kuntu minaẓ-ẓālimīn

I have done wrong.

From Surah Al-Anbiya, 21:87

What does the story teach us?



Be patient.

Wait for Allah's plan, even when things are hard.



Say sorry to Allah.

When we do something wrong, we can tell Allah we are sorry. He forgives.



Allah always hears you.

In the light or in the dark, near or far, you can always talk to Allah.

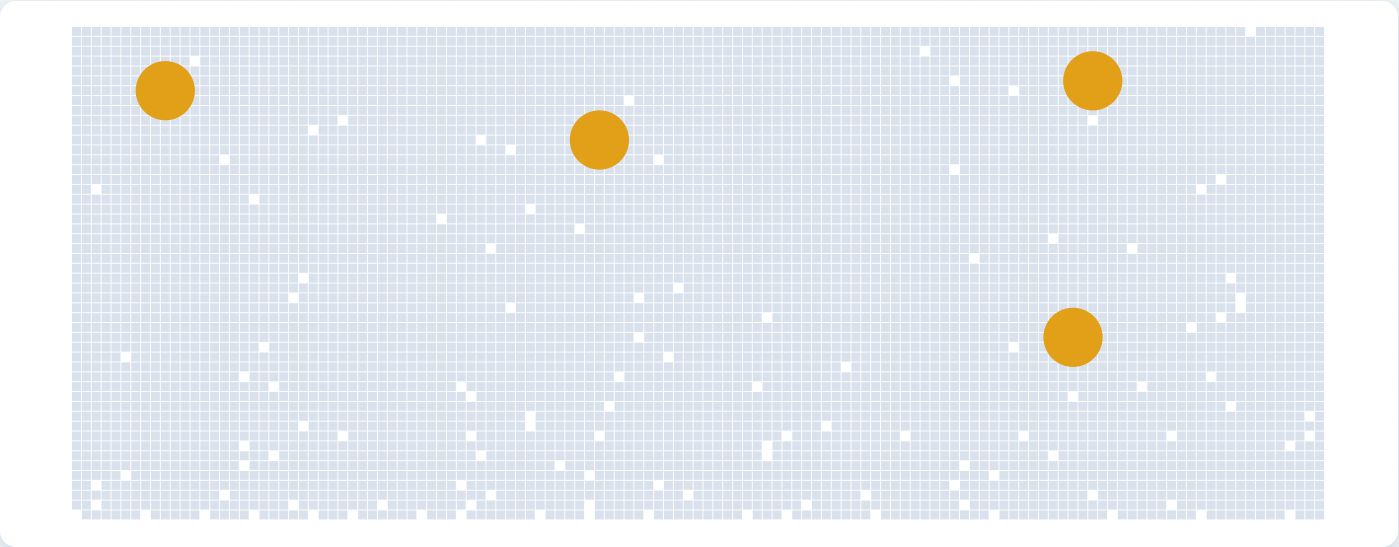


Remember Allah in good times too.

Yunus was saved because he was one of those who praise Allah.

Did you know?

Yunus's name is in just **4** verses of the Quran. **Can you find the 4 golden dots?** They are 4:163, 6:86, 10:98, 37:139.



Every verse of the Quran is one tiny square, starting at the top right like a page of the Quran. Each dot is a verse that names Yunus.

He has another name too: **Dhun-Nun**, "the one of the fish" (21:87). And a whole surah is named after him: **Surah Yunus**, number 10.

Look closer

Some pictures hide a secret from the Quran itself. Go back and find them.

p. 1	Four golden stars on the whale: Yunus is named four times in the Quran.
p. 5	The ship. The Quran calls it “the laden ship” (37:140), the very same words used for Nuh’s ark (26:119). Find the ark in book 1.
p. 7	The bowl with a dot above it is shaped like the Arabic letter ن, *nūn*. *Nūn* also means fish, which is why Yunus is called Dhun-Nun. And the surah that calls him “the one of the fish” (68:48) begins with the letter ن.
p. 10	Three gold stars for the three darknesses: the night, the sea and the fish.
p. 16	One golden gourd. The word for this plant, *yaqṭīn*, appears only once in the whole Quran (37:146).

For parents

Where the story is told. As-Saffat 37:139–148 (the ship, the lots, the fish, the shore, the gourd plant, the hundred thousand); Al-Anbiya 21:87–88 (his prayer in the darknesses); Al-Qalam 68:48–50; Yunus 10:98 (his people believed and were spared).

Told in simple words. This is a retelling for young children, not a translation. Some details come from the classical commentaries, such as Ibn Kathir's, rather than the Quran's own words: the storm, the lots drawn three times, the three darknesses, and that his people saw signs of punishment before believing. The city is not named in the Quran; tradition names it Nineveh.

The prayer. The Prophet ﷺ said that no Muslim prays with the prayer of Dhun-Nun for anything without Allah answering him (Tirmidhi 3505).

The pictures. By custom, no prophet is drawn, and in this series no person at all. The pictures show the places, the light and the creatures, so your child can picture the story around them.

Talk about it. Yunus left before Allah told him to, then said sorry in the dark. When did you last say sorry? What helps when you feel alone?

Illustrators welcome. These first pictures are a starting point. Artists are invited to redraw any book; the Books page of the Quran Atlas has a brief for every page.

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